



**“The fact that I’m me
and no one else is one
of my **greatest assets.**”**
Haruki Murakami

Self-esteem

Self-esteem relates to the way that people feel about themselves. It’s their inner sense of their own importance, value, and worth. Confidence is specific to an aspect of a person’s life, and it’s okay not to be confident in everything—but to have low self-esteem affects more than a person’s goals and abilities: it affects their mental health.

People with low self-esteem are extremely critical of themselves, and this constant stream of negative thoughts can lead to anxiety or depression. The good news is that people can choose what to think and say about themselves, and so can kick the negative thoughts, and replace them with positive opinions that are kind and affirmative.

TEEN HINTS

Building self-esteem

Self-esteem affects almost every part of a person’s life, from their relationships with others to academic and work performance, so it is essential to value yourself and give yourself the recognition that you deserve.

- Think and say positive things to yourself, about yourself, every day.
- Don’t say mean things to yourself—treat yourself like you would your best friend, with kindness and respect.
- Accept compliments from other people.
- Each day, write down three things you accomplished.

PARENT TIPS

Leading by example

Teens pick up a lot from their parents—even when their parents don’t realize it. It’s important that teens learn positive self-esteem, and so you can aim to encourage this.

- Let your teen hear you congratulate yourself when you do something well, and say good things about yourself.
- Highlight and repeat your teen’s qualities and achievements.
- Encourage resilience by talking about your own challenges with self-esteem. This will help them realize that we all struggle with self-esteem from time to time.

Shyness

Shyness is when people feel uncertain or awkward during social encounters, especially with new people. It can influence how they behave or feel around others, and make them uncomfortable, self-conscious, or nervous. Shyness can also lead to physical responses, such as blushing, sweating, breathlessness, or being unable to speak.

Shyness is quite common, but it isn’t a problem unless it causes a person emotional pain and stops them from achieving their full potential. If this occurs, it is advisable to talk to friends and family, or to see a counselor.



△ Conversation topics

Thinking about what to talk about with new people in advance can help conversation flow, and alleviate any awkward feelings.